

The Last Crusade



After the hiding he got in the Lok Sabha polls, Chautala faces an uphill task in the Assembly elections

| By Arvind Chhabra |

Om Prakash Chautala is probably fighting his last political battle to regain the state he once lorded over. And he's promising more than the moon to win the votes he needs to get that done. Consider these pledges from the Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) chief: Waiver of loans up to Rs 1 lakh, Rs 3,000 per month to every unemployed person who has completed school education, free education for students of degree classes, 25 kg of foodgrain for the poor, scooters for girl students, free LPG gas connection with stove and cylinder for every family and 13 months' salary for women employees every year. The INLD manifesto is rich with many more such avowals. And it figures: At 74, out of power and comprehensively drubbed in his last electoral outing, Chautala is desperate. The Lok Sabha elections in May which he fought in alliance with the BJP saw the INLD failing to register a single win. That alliance has now been severed which makes his chances even slimmer.

With all alliances having broken down, parties are fighting their individual battles in a five-cornered contest. The INLD

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